disadvantage. So long as he single-handedly continued to control Indian policy, the Chinese had a pretty good idea of how India would act. Mao was much too shrewd a campaigner and Chinese intelligence was extremely up-to-date—there was no way that the Forward Policy would be seen as a provocative act. However, having laid the trap by declaring a second claim line, the Chinese promptly branded the Indian counter moves as ‘can shi zheng ce’—a nibbling policy—based on the analogy of silkworms eating mulberry leaves until they are fully consumed.

Even today, most Chinese analyses argue that India was planning to take an aggressive stance in Tibet. They have persevered with the theory that India’s objective was always to undermine Chinese attempts to rule Tibet so that India could turn it into a protectorate of its own. So long as this assumption continues to be put forth, and the issue is seen only from the Chinese point of view, the Forward Policy will continue to be labelled as India’s biggest folly. In reality, the Indians had been patrolling much further forward prior to the directives being issued for the implementation of the Forward Policy. Now they were more or less operating within the Indian border in the area between the two claim lines set down by the Chinese. Maxwell and others who characterize this as the main provocation that hardened the Chinese stance are buying China’s argument. That India had security concerns of its own is ignored and the implication is that she was continuing to act on British expansionist policy.

Many Indian writers have echoed Maxwell simply because the Australian journalist, having had access to parts of the secret and classified Henderson Brooks-Bhagat Report, acquired a degree of credibility for ‘being in the know’. The hardening of China’s stance was more likely to be related to the fact that the Dalai Lama had not only been given political asylum, he had been welcomed with open arms. In addition, the Indian stand on the border issue that no talks were possible unless China first withdrew from the Aksai Chin possibly hardened China’s stand. From a Chinese perspective, their own position on NEFA was reasonable while India’s rigidness on not wanting to exchange the two areas was unreasonable.

Prime Minister Nehru, having kept his countrymen in the dark over the differences with China for almost half a decade, now found himself manoeuvring through a political minefield of his own making; both in Parliament and with the media he was no longer the man with an